

Pikachu Went to Space, and Now It Is Helping Celebrate World Space Week

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Pikachu has officially been to space! The European Space Agency, or ESA, revealed on September 19, 2026, that a special Pikachu **plush** toy spent 67 days on the **International Space Station**, or ISS. Now that space trip is part of World Space Week, which runs from October 4 through 10 this year.

The **plush** "astronaut" blasted off to the ISS on April 11 aboard a Cygnus **cargo spacecraft**. It came back to Earth on June 17 on a SpaceX Dragon **cargo spacecraft**. While it was in **orbit**, Pikachu traveled around Earth about 1,040 times.

ESA timed the mission to kick off World Space Week 2026. To celebrate, the agency created a special **exhibit** that mixes real space science with Pokémon characters. Visitors can see displays about Europe's space missions and what life is like on the ISS. They can also learn how ESA studies the Sun, the **solar system** and the rest of the universe.

The **exhibit** opened at ESA's headquarters in Paris, France, in late September. It will travel to museums and other places across Europe until April 2027.

Pokémon GO players can join in, too. From October 4, 2026, through April 30, 2027, players who visit participating science and space museums in Europe can take part in special activities. These include One-Star Raids featuring Astronaut Pikachu, research tasks and chances to find event-themed Pokémon.

ESA hopes the project will make kids and teens curious about space and science. "Inspiring future generations is a key part of ESA's mission," said Josef Aschbacher, the head of ESA.

Word Treasure

plush -- A plush toy is a soft, stuffed toy covered in fuzzy fabric.

International Space Station -- The International Space Station is a science lab that circles Earth with astronauts living on board.

cargo spacecraft -- A cargo spacecraft is a ship that carries supplies to and from space instead of people.

orbit -- To be in orbit means to travel in a curved path around a planet or other object in space.

exhibit -- An exhibit is a public display of objects or information, often at a museum.

solar system -- The solar system is the Sun and all the planets, moons and other objects that travel around it.

Background you need

The International Space Station is a large laboratory that orbits Earth, where astronauts live and do experiments.

Cargo spacecraft like Cygnus and SpaceX Dragon carry supplies, equipment and experiments to the station and back without a crew on board.

The European Space Agency is a group of European countries that work together on space missions and science.

World Space Week is a yearly celebration in early October that encourages people, especially young people, to learn about space.

Break it down

LEAD: A Pikachu plush toy spent 67 days on the International Space Station

KEY EVENT: ESA revealed the trip on September 19, 2026, to kick off World Space Week

+ - WHEN: Launched April 11, returned June 17, about 1,040 orbits

+ - HOW: Up on a Cygnus cargo ship, back on a SpaceX Dragon

CELEBRATION: A space-and-Pokémon exhibit touring Europe until April 2027

GAME TIE-IN: Pokémon GO raids with Astronaut Pikachu at European museums through April 30, 2027

GOAL: ESA head Josef Aschbacher says inspiring future generations is key to ESA's mission

Why it matters

Space agencies use popular characters like Pikachu to spark young people's interest in science, which could inspire the next generation of scientists and astronauts.

Test what you remember

1. How many days did the Pikachu plush spend on the International Space Station?

- ☐ (A) 7 days
- ☐ (B) 1,040 days
- ☐ (C) 100 days
- ☐ (D) 67 days

2. Which spacecraft carried Pikachu to the space station?

- ☐ (A) The space shuttle
- ☐ (B) An Apollo capsule
- ☐ (C) A Cygnus cargo spacecraft
- ☐ (D) A SpaceX Dragon

3. About how many times did Pikachu travel around Earth?

- ☐ (A) About 10 times
- ☐ (B) About 10,000 times
- ☐ (C) About 67 times
- ☐ (D) About 1,040 times

4. When does World Space Week run this year?

- ☐ (A) All of 2027
- ☐ (B) April 11 to June 17
- ☐ (C) September 19 to 30
- ☐ (D) October 4 through 10

5. Where did ESA's exhibit open?

- ☐ (A) ESA's headquarters in Paris, France
- ☐ (B) New York City
- ☐ (C) On the space station
- ☐ (D) Tokyo, Japan

6. What does ESA hope the project will do?

- ☐ (A) Sell more toys
- ☐ (B) Make kids and teens curious about space and science
- ☐ (C) Replace astronauts with toys
- ☐ (D) Build a new space station

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: D 4: D 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):